

« This generation is a lot smarter than we were, but at the same time, I feel they are a lot softer than we were »

SAINA NEHWAL

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

While she might have last played a competitive match in 2023 (at the Singapore Open), Saina Nehwal's never officially called time on her international career. Speaking to Sportstar magazine on the sidelines of the Legends Vision Legacy Tour, Saina addresses why she never felt the need to announce her retirement, the challenge of being a pioneer in Indian women's badminton, what she feels her legacy is, and what she thinks the future holds for Indian women's singles.

You never officially announced your retirement. Why is that?

I never saw the point in doing this. When I entered badminton, I didn't make any big announcement either. It's the same thing when you leave. Sometimes I'll have dreams that I might come back. It's been six months since I took cortisone injections in my knees. Then I'll remember just how badly they are

damaged. I already have arthritis in them. The doctor told me that if it had just been an ACL injury, it could have been repaired, but this is cartilage degeneration that has built up over many years. Your body is just giving up. The cartilage is almost gone. So the joints are rubbing against each other, which is causing inflammation.

It's not that I don't want to play, but the option is not there. The body is a machine, and once the machine stops working, there's only so much you can do to keep getting it ready.

What does life after badminton look like?

It's challenging. You are looking for things to do. I do a lot of events and motivational talks. Right now, I'm part of the Legends Vision Legacy Tour, where we collect old badminton racquets and give them to underprivileged children to get them into the sport. I was a judge at the Miss Universe Pageant, which was pretty exciting as well. Coaching

is always an option in the future. The good thing is that you have gone through so much stress and pressure for so many years, so you are looking to enjoy being a normal person for some time.

At the same time, I had been playing internationally since I was 13 or 14. Back then, I wanted to play forever. As a sports person, happiness for me came from winning.

That cycle of winning and losing is what motivated you to go through the same drill every day. It was a very simple, regimented life. I knew what time I had to sleep, what I had to eat, and what I shouldn't do on a Sunday. It seems restrictive, but I started liking it, especially when you stand on a podium with a medal.

But while your mind wants to do it forever, your body doesn't let you. You get slower. If you want to play at the highest level, your body needs to be able to handle 9-10 hours of training. But that was not possible for me. My knees started giving up,